

# Mark Stringer

Three Fringe Shows, 2024-2026

Delivering the Impossible - The Biscuit Tin and the Biscuit - You Can Write a Book



MARK STRINGER

# DELIVERING THE IMPOSSIBLE

A thick, horizontal red brushstroke with a textured, hand-painted appearance, positioned below the title.

**A Short Talk About How to  
Rule the World**

“I didn’t expect this to be so interesting”

# Delivering the Impossible

## A Short Talk About How to Rule the World

Clover Studio, Greenside @ Riddle's Court, 322 Lawnmarket, Edinburgh EH1 2PG  
Edinburgh Festival Fringe, 12-24 August 2024 (not Sun 18th) - 1:45pm, 45 minutes

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Software is eating everything: food, romance, television. The people who know how to manage making it - Bezos, Musk, Zuckerberg - end up running the world. This was Mark Stringer's first full Fringe run, built from a working software project manager's point of view: projects treated as bets, struggling delivery as a pirate ship nobody wants to look at, bad news treated as data rather than a threat. The talk argues that a better point of view is worth more than a better method, and that most software isn't so much finished as helped to escape into real use. Forty-five minutes of the argument that later became his book, *Delivering the Impossible*, tried out loud on a small Edinburgh audience before it was tried out in print. One audience member called it 'knowledge about project management I wouldn't acquire elsewhere.'

### Main points

- Point of view is worth 80 IQ points: how you see a project matters more than which method you follow
- Every project is a bet, not a guaranteed outcome
- Struggling projects have a 'pirate ship' everyone in the room is ignoring
- Delivery is less about finishing software and more about helping it escape into real use
- Agile practice injects 'some' into people's desire for 'all'
- Project management isn't really about exact promises; it's about delivering value under uncertainty

# Mark Stringer



## The Biscuit Tin and the Biscuit

Biscuits are delicious. Creativity is hard.



**GREENSIDE AT  
RIDDLE'S COURT**  
VENUE 16

'Encapsulating the spirit of the fringe'  
Riddle's Court, 322 Lawnmarket,  
Edinburgh, EH1 2PG

**CLOVER  
STUDIO**

The Biscuit Tin and  
the Biscuit  
11TH — 23RD August  
18:20 (0hr 45m)

£10.00 (Full) £5:00 (Concession)

BUY TICKETS HERE



**fringe**  
The Edinburgh Festival

# The Biscuit Tin and the Biscuit

**Biscuits are delicious. Creativity is hard.**

Clover Studio, Greenside @ Riddle's Court, 322 Lawnmarket, Edinburgh EH1 2PG

Edinburgh Festival Fringe, 11-23 August 2025 - 18:20, 45 minutes (previewed at Brighton Fringe, 9 May 2025)

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A biscuit tin is not a biscuit. An idea, a plan, a description of the thing you mean to make is different from the thing itself, and the gap between them is where all the difficulty - and all the interest - lives. Mark Stringer's second show follows that gap through writing, project management, language learning and improvisation, arguing that creativity is emotional labour, not just talent: frustration, perfectionism, hesitation, the urge to stop. It borrows the structure of Bake Off - where getting better doesn't mean getting more confident, it means arriving at new and more elaborate forms of not knowing - and applies it to any kind of making. It proposes three ways through: know your real capacity, have an honest conversation with the work, and sometimes just decide. 'Fuck it, I am going to do this.'

## Main points

- The biscuit tin is the idea; the biscuit is the real thing you actually make
- Turning one into the other always produces emotion, not just technical difficulty
- Getting better at something doesn't mean feeling more confident - it means facing new kinds of not knowing
- Perfectionism and 'agreed activity' are two of the most common ways people avoid real progress
- Know your actual capacity rather than setting impossible targets
- Have a real conversation with the work instead of forcing it or avoiding it
- Some progress only happens after a decisive, unglamorous commitment

# YOU CAN WRITE A BOOK!



**GREENSIDE AT  
RIDDLE'S COURT**  
VENUE 16

'Encapsulating the spirit of the fringe'  
Riddle's Court, 322 Lawnmarket,  
Edinburgh, EH1 2PG

**CLOVER  
STUDIO**

**You Can Write A Book!  
(Mark Stringer)**

**17th – 29th August (No Show 23rd)**

**18:20 (50 mins)**

**BUY TICKETS HERE**



**Edinburgh  
fringe**



# You Can Write a Book

Clover Studio, Greenside @ Riddle's Court, 322 Lawnmarket, Edinburgh EH1 2PG

Edinburgh Festival Fringe, 17-29 August 2026 (not Sundays) - 18:20, 50 minutes - £10 / £5 concession

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Mark Stringer has a book out and doesn't know how to market it. His first idea for the show's title was Please Buy My Book; he decided that was a bit on the nose. So instead, in fifty minutes, he talks to a room of strangers about how they could write a book too - using the same ideas about drafts, hesitation and turning ideas into real things that got his own book written, and that carried his last two shows at the Fringe. Where last year's show argued that the idea of a thing and the thing itself are made of different stuff, this one asks the audience to close that gap themselves: everyone in the room actually writes something, instead of just hearing about writing. Part sales pitch, part masterclass, part continuation of an argument that started with a biscuit tin.

## Main points

- In fifty minutes, the audience leaves with real, usable ideas about how to start a book
- Continues the two-show arc: last year was the idea of the book, this year is making it
- Everyone in the room actually writes something during the show, rather than just hearing about writing
- Draws on the techniques Mark used to build the show itself: talking ideas out loud, shitty first drafts, rehearsing to near-empty rooms
- Doubles as a way of talking about Delivering the Impossible without directly asking people to buy it